

but lacks the included effects that jQuery offers. For that, developers will need script.aculo.us, a library that is discussed later in this chapter. Both frameworks have benefits, but the libraries of code built around them, in the form of plugins or extensions, is what really makes them useful in WordPress.

4.6 Leveraging WordPress' JavaScript libraries

JavaScript frameworks bundled in WordPress are powerful pieces of software that allow for quick and clean JavaScript development. With these libraries, developers can radically alter the way a theme behaves or how a user interacts with the WordPress Admin. The preferred library in WordPress development is jQuery, but some developers are just more familiar with Prototype, especially if they have come from a Ruby on Rails background. Both libraries can be used in conjunction with each other.

In the next section, I'll introduce you to the JavaScript libraries (extensions to the JavaScript frameworks) that are bundled with WordPress. This should not prevent developers from including other frameworks manually if they prefer to do so.

Prototype: script.aculo.us

Built on Prototype, script.aculo.us (<http://script.aculo.us/>) is a series of libraries that provides effects, animations, and other user interface enhancements. It is not used anywhere in the WordPress core, but is provided as a legacy library for plugins that need it. The script.aculo.us library provides plenty of effects that can be useful in plugin development. Some include the capability to make page elements semi-transparent (opacity) in a cross-browser fashion, moving elements on the screen, and Ajax data retrieval.

The main downfall to script.aculo.us is its weight (it weighs in at a hefty 632K), so it is not recommended that plugins load the entire library. You can choose to load the entire suite or just the portions needed, but make sure you load all the dependent libraries as well.

Prototype: TinyMCE

Many rich text editors are available on the web. TinyMCE was adopted into the WordPress core because it is lightweight, is entirely General Public License (GPL) – compatible, and the team behind TinyMCE was willing to work closely with WordPress to develop a product that could be distributed to millions of blogs.